

Binary Blobs

Binary Blobs are mysterious pieces of code, (possibly closed source), injected into Open Source projects, with no documentation or explanation



Read an interesting article on e-waste at <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/eslums/>

Feature



Watch your loved ones admiring themselves!

free Brain Age clones whose demo versions are very generous. There's tremendous value to be unlocked from usage, and loyalties are made through products that deliver. My dad still uses an iPod Shuffle that I got for him five years ago. It still works.

If my employers were to give me any notebook of my choosing, I'd go for the highest end Macbook, the best computing experience, but since I finance my own tech, I have an Acer Aspire netbook with a 12-inch screen that I purchased for Rs. 24,000, four months ago. It's now available for Rs. 19,000, and getting more obsolete by the day.

Where am I going with all of this? Well, it's an enquiry into everyone's double standards. As a tech journalist, I've reviewed everything from game controllers to graphic cards, motherboards and processors, laptops and phones and games.

My idea for Switchclick comes with the realisation that when computers get junked, they can be poi-

sonous to the environment. Instead, they can be refurbished, repurposed, and crafted to make value out of scrap.

Harshit Patel, who runs Techshop.in, an e-commerce site that sells computer hardware, and also has an e-cycle program on the web site, agreed to give me a glimpse of the recycling industry in Mumbai, which, according to a 2007 Guardian article, employs around 2,50,000 people.

Dead computers and their galaxy of components have in them a number of rare earths and precious metals (gold, palladium, neodymium, etc.) worth recycling, but also contain a number of toxic substances that can spill into the ecosystem. The laundry list of toxic chemicals include: arsenic, brominated flame retardants (BFRs), mercury, phthalates, and polyvinyl chloride (PVC). These are being eliminated by many manufacturers, and Greenpeace has been keeping tabs on everyone including Apple and Nintendo.

E-waste is a serious problem, a PTI wire story from 2009 reports that



A cool and interesting application for old hard disks

e-waste from discarded computers, TVs and mobile phones will cross 8-lakh tonnes by 2012. According to a greenpeace report, India generated 3.8 lakh tonnes of waste. Only three percent of it is recycled, says Nitin Gupta, CEO of Attero Recycling, one of the few Indian companies that legally processes e-waste.

Attero Recycling has been given permission for import of 8000 metric tonnes of hazardous e-waste from UK and USA, but reiterates on a best practices page that the focus will be on domestic e-waste recycling. They have been organizing collection drives in residential areas and have a direct number that anyone can call to dispose of electronic waste.

But the problem does little to address the informal industry that handles 97% of electronic waste.

Recyclism and Makers

Cory Doctorow, co-founder of Boing-boing.net, has a has free to download

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